

that they want diet-book-style “actionable steps” or “better forecasting tools,” satisfying the profile of the eventual Black Swan victim. We will see further that, in an ailment similar to confirmation bias, charlatans provide the much demanded positive advice (what to do), as people do not value negative advice (what not to do). Now, “how not to go bust” does not appear to be valid advice, yet, given that over time only a minority of companies do not go bust, avoiding death is the best possible—and most robust—advice. (It is particularly good advice after your competitors get in trouble and you can go on legal pillages of their businesses.)^{*} Also, many readers (say, those who work in forecasting or banking) do not often understand that the “actionable step” for them is to simply quit their profession and do something more ethical.

In addition to playing into our mental biases, and telling people what they want to hear, these “idea books” often have an abhorrent definitive and investigative tone to their messages, like the reports of management consultants trying to make you believe that they told you more than they actually did. I came up with a simple compression test using a version of what is called Kolmogorov complexity, a measure of how much a message can be reduced without losing its integrity: try to reduce a book to the shortest length possible without losing any of its intended message or aesthetic effects. My friend the novelist Rolf Dobelli (he does not seem to like to walk slowly and drags me on hikes in the Alps), an owner of a firm that abstracts books and sells the summaries to busy businesspeople, convinced me that his firm has a lofty mission, as almost all business books can be reduced to a few pages without any loss of their message and essence; novels and philosophical treatments cannot be compressed.

So a philosophical essay is a beginning, not an end. To me the very same meditation continues from book to book, compared to the work of a nonfiction writer, who will, say, move to another distinct and journalistically confined topic. I want my contribution to be a new way of viewing knowledge, the very beginning of a long investigation, the start of something real. Indeed, I am glad at the time of writing, a few years into the life of the book, to see the idea spread among thoughtful readers, inspiring like-minded scholars to go beyond it and seeding research in epistemology, engineering, education, defense, operations research, statistics, political theory, sociology, climate studies, medicine, law, aesthetics, and insurance (though not so much in the area in which *The Black Swan* found Black Swan-style near instant vindication, economics).

I was lucky that it only took a couple of years (and a severe financial